minister to give the trade union leader an ultimatum, and his unflinchingly facing the ire of the striking workers had impressed JRD. These and other instances like his daring aerobatics in the single-engine aircraft in the US as a student were testimonies to his steely resolve and self-assurance.

When it came to enterprise, Ratan had displayed his capacity for long-term thinking by unveiling his strategic plans for the group. He followed this up with the establishment of more than half a dozen new enterprises, most of them in high-tech and some in areas where the group had no presence. JRD said, ‘He has also been responsible for reactivating Tata Industries which had set up a number of interesting companies in high-tech areas.’ He added, ‘Ratan has done a very good job at TELCO of modernizing production facilities and diversifying the product range into lighter and smaller vehicles.’

Besides age, courage and enterprise, JRD had emphasized that his successor should have extraordinary vision, realizing that new opportunities would abound in the changing Indian economic landscape. Nothing was perhaps more emblematic of Ratan’s vision than his Strategic Plan.

‘He had the vision we could not see,’ says Ishaat Hussain, a Tata lifer and former director in Tata Sons. It was not only his colleagues who noted this attribute. Former US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger said of Ratan: ‘He is extremely well prepared and thinking not only of the immediate problem but of the long-range problem. Because he has an extraordinary combination of analytic intelligence, historical perspective and tough business knowhow, he is able to take extraordinary decisions.’

Syamal Gupta recalled that JRD was impressed with Ratan’s vision that incorporated a global outlook. The need to grow outside India was amongst the important recommendations that Ratan had made in his Strategic Plan. The meeting of minds with JRD was unmistakable.

Another aspect that JRD was impressed with was Ratan’s deep understanding of technology. He said that ‘Ratan is a great believer in modern technology and strategic planning.’ His judgement was prescient. During his tenure as group chairman, this quality of Ratan’s played out most prominently.

As Tridibesh Mukherjee—one of India’s foremost metallurgists and former group director of Technology and Integration at Corus Group—says, Ratan had the vision to understand that technology would be the main driver of future business. Technology was at the core of the restructuring